



“Are you in control?”

a relevant message. Of course, this message should stop once the user has adopted the intended usage of the features.

Saying little while saying enough involves finding a balance. Zen-like balance.

Are you saying too much, or are you saying too little?

The Control Principle

The “experience” in ‘User eXperience’ belongs to the user. As UX designers, we don’t create the experience itself, we create the framework for the users within which they have the experience. When they make their own choices, users feel in control, but here too, there’s a need for balance. Too many choices can leave a user feeling helpless, unable to decide on the next step, while no choices convey a total lack of control. According to the Hick-Hyman law, the time it takes to make a decision increases logarithmically with the number of alternatives. Thus, the number of choices available and the degree of control also affects the design’s efficiency. Did you give the user enough control to feel autonomous?

Sometimes, it’s better to allow multiple paths to exist towards a common overarching goal, including a path of least resistance. Can the user do the same thing in another way? It’s also advisable to let the user have a sense of where they’re in the workflow, and allow them the opportunity to move both, backward and forward. Does the user always know where they are within the system? Think of how useful the undo and redo features are. Making actions reversible gives users confidence and reduces the chances